

Chemotherapy explained

Chemotherapy uses drugs to treat cancer. It can be given in different ways and will be carefully planned.

Chemotherapy

Chemotherapy drugs are used to treat many different types of cancer. They are most commonly given into a vein or as tablets or capsules.

Side effects of chemotherapy

Chemotherapy treatment can cause different side effects. Your doctor or nurse can help you control and manage them.

How chemotherapy is given

Chemotherapy can be given in different ways depending on the type of cancer you have and your treatment plan.

Central lines

A central line is a long, thin hollow tube. It is put into a vein in your chest and used to give chemotherapy and other drugs.

PICC lines

A PICC line is a long, thin, flexible tube which is put into the arm to give chemotherapy and other treatments.

Cannulas

A cannula is a short, thin tube that is put into a vein in your arm or the back of your hand for treatment. It will be removed before you go home.

Implantable ports

An implantable port is a tube with a rubber disc at the end. It sits under the skin and can be used to give chemotherapy or other treatments.

Intrathecal chemotherapy

Chemotherapy given into the fluid around the brain and spinal cord is called intrathecal chemotherapy. It is given during a lumbar puncture.

Chemotherapy and pregnancy

Most people who have had chemotherapy when they are pregnant have healthy babies. You can usually start chemotherapy after you are 14 weeks pregnant.

How we can help



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.



Cancer information in other formats and languages

We have information about chemotherapy in 16 different languages and other formats, including audiobooks and easy read booklets. You can also request information in any language or format.